SPECIAL REPORT

MANIPUR

RETURN TO ANARCHY

CENTRAL AND STATE INACTION HAS LED TO A RENEWED FLARE-UP IN VIOLENCE IN MANIPUR. THE DIVISIONS GO MUCH DEEPER NOW, PEACE SEEMS THAT MORE UNATTAINABLE

BY KAUSHIK DEKA

If Manipur had begun to slip from the nation's consciousness, September served up a brutal reminder of just how fragile the situation still is in the war-torn state. On the first day of the month, violent clashes erupted—this time between armed groups of the Kuki-Zo and the security forces—along the fraught boundary separating the Meitei-dominated Imphal West and the Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi districts. In the days that followed, fresh clashes between ethnic factions engulfed areas like Jiribam and Bishnupur, leaving at least seven dead. The violence has even invaded spaces meant for dialogue, with Jiribam—a site of recent peace talks between Meitei and Hmar leaders (a sub-group of the larger Kuki-Zo community)—becoming a battlefield. The arsenal of violence has escalated dangerously, with Kuki insurgents allegedly deploying weaponised drones and rocket-propelled grenades, marking a new and chilling phase in the conflict (see *Manipur's Flying Threats...*).

As though on cue, the horrors of Manipur's first phase of ethnic strife, which ignited on May 3 last year, have resurfaced in full force. Internet services have been severed, armouries looted, and the streets are once again roiling with protesters. The bitter rivalry between the Meitei and Kuki communities—sparked by a court order that sought to extend the Kukis' special economic privileges to the Meiteis—has only deepened.

Over the past 16 months, ethnic violence in Manipur has claimed more than 200 lives and displaced over 60,000 people, many of whom now live in relief camps scattered across the state or have fled beyond its borders. Yet, amid this humanitarian disaster, there has been one constant: Chief Minister N. Biren Singh. Despite growing calls for action—particularly from the Kuki community and the Opposition—the BJP-led Union government has steadfastly refused to replace Biren or impose President's Rule, a move some believe could stabilise the situation. This reluctance has baffled many, especially given the scale of the ongoing crisis.

Manipur, a state of 3.2 million people, has effectively been carved into two enclaves: the Meitei-dominated Imphal Valley and the Kuki-controlled hill districts. Both regions have been ethnically cleansed of the rival group, with no prospect of return for those displaced. The division is so entrenched that even administra-



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▲ **NO END IN SIGHT** A students' protest in Imphal city, Sept. 10; CM N. Biren Singh